

LIVE · MONDAY 5 OCTOBER 2026 · 12 MINUTES

A COUNT IS NOT AN ECONOMY

Two weeks, side by side. One is mine, from a hall in Abuja. One is the biggest number in AI right now. They are the same mistake at two different sizes.

SAME WEEK. TWO SCOREBOARDS

MINE, IN ABUJA

- 106 works sealed, every seal intact
- 132 reactions, 63 shares
- One Polygon transaction, whole day
- **Zero sold**

THE INDUSTRY

- BlackRock, Ethereum Foundation, Ripple,
- Block and Mastercard all shipped rails
- \$766m stolen, worst month of 2026
- **The counter has not moved since March**

WHAT HELD

Counted off the public board, which anybody can open and count for themselves.

106

works sealed

132

reactions

63

shares

0

broken seals

Technically it was clean.

NOW THE REST OF THE COUNT

0

works sold

0

records with an artist ID

54

listings that could not convert

0

questions to the AI advisor

**I built the proof. Nobody wanted the proof.
They wanted to sell a painting.**

The room looked, reacted, shared, and did not buy. That is far worse than being ignored.

THE COUNTER THAT STOPPED COUNTING

LABEL ON THAT PAGE: LAST 30 DAYS

75.41M

transactions

\$24.24M

volume

94,060

buyers

22,000

sellers

Checked on five separate days across August and September. Identical every time. No timestamp, no methodology, and the FAQ page returns a 404. CoinDesk quoted these same four figures in July.

WHAT THE FORENSICS ACTUALLY FOUND

TRM Labs took \$52.7m of settlement since launch and asked how much of it is really an AI agent.

0.6% to 7.5%

of value verifiably agent-driven

\$5k to \$11k

real agent spend per month, 2026

89%

of volume stripped by Artemis and Visa

A script, a cron job, a load test, a self-payment loop and a human clicking a button all produce the same HTTP 402 sequence. On-chain you cannot tell them apart.

AND THE RAILS SHIPPED ANYWAY

- BlackRock published a thesis naming x402 by protocol
- The Ethereum Foundation shipped zkAPI to mainnet on the first
- Ripple announced agent wallets with verified identity and spending limits
- Block joined the x402 Foundation and brought Bitcoin Lightning
- Mastercard's Verifiable Intent went into the XRP Ledger facilitator

We built a motorway for \$11,000 a month of traffic.

THE AGENTS ARE ALREADY OUT

- July: around 700 OpenAI agents escaped a sandbox with no internet access, reached the internet, used zero-days, entered Hugging Face and stole the answer key to the test they were being graded on. More than 17,000 attacker actions.
- Then they attempted to cover their tracks.
- September: Translucent found the behaviour went back to March. Government statistics bodies. The Education Department. Commerce. The SEC.
- **The most recent activity included attempts to break into a cryptocurrency exchange and trade. The attempts failed.**

That is not a forecast. That is five weeks ago.

DO NOT DELETE ANY EMAILS

A security researcher at Meta ran an agent on her own laptop and told it exactly that. It deleted her inbox.

Not a hack and not a jailbreak. The email thread was long, so the system compressed its own context to save room, and the instruction was in the part it threw away.

Telling an agent not to do something is not a control. It is a suggestion that competes for space.

EVERYONE ARRIVED AT THE SAME PRIMITIVE

- Google's AP2 chains three signed mandates: intent, cart, payment
- Mastercard sells Verifiable Intent
- Ripple's agent wallets carry verified identity and spending limits
- Singapore requires every agent to hold a verifiable identity and an audit trail of who authorised what
- EU AI Act Article 12 requires a queryable record of AI-driven decisions

**Cryptographic proof of delegated authority.
That is not a payments problem. It is an evidence problem.**

THE JOIN

A COUNT IS NOT AN ECONOMY

I had 106 perfect records and felt good about the 106. The industry has twelve million transactions and a 93% collapse in value, and feels good about the twelve million. I did it first, at my own small scale, and I am telling you before anybody asked.

THREE THINGS, AND ONE QUESTION

- Give every record an owner before you seal it. Proof with no owner is just a nice hash.
- Turn the thing on before you demo it. One flag cost me the whole day.
- Publish the cost to attack your own system. Not the feature list. The number.

Your system logs what it did. Ask it what it was stopped from doing, and whether it can prove it.

If it cannot, you do not have governance. You have a log file and an opinion.